a more realistic defensive position on the northern slopes of the Tsangdhar, if not even further back.

However, as he handed over command of 7 Brigade back to John Dalvi after the firing started, Kaul's orders were unambiguous on one point. Says Dalvi: 'We were to hold our position, that is the south bank of the Nam Ka Chu and ensure the security of the crossings from Temporary Bridge to Bridge 1 at all costs.' The departing general also told Lieutenant Colonel Rikh that the Indian troops were not to advance across the Nam Ka Chu as 'the situation had changed and the enemy was reacting more violently than he had anticipated'.

Kaul's own version of events in his autobiography confirms this: 'I had seen with my own eyes the superior resources of Chinese in the battle that morning, and the untenability of our position in Dhola area located in a hollow. *I was also advised by the Divisional Commander* (italics mine) that I should go to Delhi and ask Army Headquarters and the Government not to press us to "expel" the Chinese from this area, a task which was beyond our capacity and that we should occupy a position where we could be better placed vis-à-vis the enemy. Dalvi had also the same view. I agreed with both the Divisional and Brigade Commander.'

With their respective commands back, Niranjan Prasad and John Dalvi could turn their attention to the serious problems faced by the depleted, half-starved and under-equipped 7 Brigade, problems that they had, in the last few days, watched with dismay and professional discernment grow by the minute. Even as he departed, Kaul had tied their hands with that one final order: that there could be no changes in the ground positions until he himself cleared it. They had no choice but to try and maintain these untenable positions until Kaul's orders changed. To be fair to Kaul, the moment he reached Delhi the next morning, he presented his alarming assessment to Army HQ and to the prime minister. Nehru convened a meeting at his residence, Teen Murti, in the evening of 11 October. Apart from Nehru and Kaul, also present were the defence minister, Krishna Menon, the COAS, General Pran Thapar, the air chief, Aspy Engineer, the cabinet secretary, S. S. Khera, the foreign secretary, M. J. Desai, the Intelligence Bureau Chief, B. N. Mullik, and the Eastern Army Commander, Bogey Sen. Kaul, true to his word, did not change his stance and clearly spelt out the Indian position at Nam Ka Chu. His first-hand account described the situation on the ground lucidly, explaining in detail